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Player Habits in Mario Kart World

Abstract

Mario Kart World is the latest game in the Mario Kart series, which was released for the Nintendo Switch 2 on June 5th, 2025. The game adds many new features, such as 24 players instead of 12 players, knockout tours, intermissions, free roam, and a bunch of new characters to the roster. Studying gaming habits matters in today's world because certain key traits can be found in different players, such as casual versus competitive play patterns, for example. The purpose of this study is to simply analyze the behavioral differences between casual and competitive Mario Kart World players in the community. To start things off, I created a Google form and posted the form in many communities, such as the Mario Kart World Lounge Discord server, the r/MarioKartWorld subreddit, and several collegiate Mario Kart Discord servers. As of the writing of this paper, there have been a total of 605 survey respondents. The survey required players to input anonymous responses such as their community activity, hours played, current rank in Lounge, mogi (match) participation, and play frequency. Some key findings from the dataset were that competitive players show significantly higher hours, daily frequency, community engagement, and content creation. There was also a preference divergence between 12-player and 24-player events among casual and competitive players.



Credit: @shamchez

Literature Review

Wang proposed a framework of gaming motivations that aligns with the research's segmentation logic, distinguishing between casual and competitive gaming, and can help theorize differences

in motivation (Wang, 2022). Berzenski directly studied the differences between competitive and non-competitive gamers, which is very relevant to the aim of comparing both groups in the survey (Berzenski et al., 2025). Banyai explored the motivations for becoming an esports or pro-level gamer, which provides insight into what drives highly engaged gamers. This would be useful for discussing the competition, skill development, and social aspects as well (Banyai et al., 2020). Martucci reviewed how various gaming motivations, including competition, escapism, and socializing, relate to problematic gaming, offering a critical lens on competitive play and mental health (Martucci et al., 2023). Backlund and his colleagues helped contextualize motivations versus harmful engagement, which is pretty useful for discussing well-being or risks associated with heavy or competitive play (Backlund et al., 2022). Kelly investigated health and well-being outcomes of competitive online gaming among young people, which is relevant for addressing potential negative or positive externalities of competitive habits (Kelly et al., 2021). Wischert-Zielke and Barke recently conducted a study on motivation, addiction risk, and gaming behavior among recreational players, which is useful for contrasting casual players with competitive players (Wischert-Zielke & Barke, 2023). Nathan explored behavior in casual gaming contexts, which is useful for supporting arguments about how casual versus competitive players view performance, cooperation, and social dynamics differently (Nathan et al., 2025, preprint). Bosboom researched how and why Mario Kart is hard for new players who are trying to get into competitive gaming while analyzing it as a racing video game phenomenon. The following article serves as groundwork prior to this research on Mario Kart specifically (Bosboom et al., 2016).



Credit: @shamchez

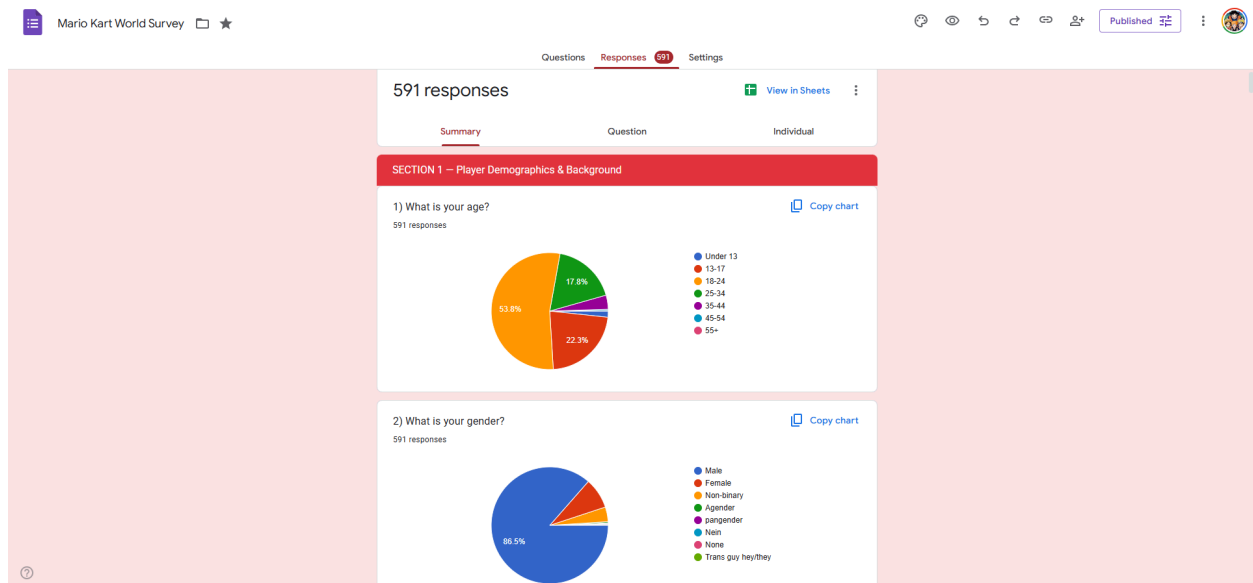
Methods

I made the survey so that it was designed for everyone, from casual to competitive players and those in between. I was trying to gather insights into players' experiences with Mario Kart World globally, including favorite tracks, preferred vehicle combos, competition habits, and community

vibes as well. On average, the survey took approximately 5 to 10 minutes to complete for each person and only took anonymous responses in order to maintain privacy. The replies assisted my own graduate research in order to comprehend player behavior worldwide, the development of skills, and what makes Mario Kart World enjoyable for everyone. As mentioned before, 605 people filled out the survey. The survey was posted in some Discord servers and on Reddit as well. After I gathered a decent sample size, I converted all of the Google Form responses into a Google spreadsheet. Next, I had to do some data cleaning, such as question #3 from the survey, for example. The following question asked which country the player was from. Obviously, there were multiple ways a person could respond with “United States,” such as “United States of America,” “USA,” & “US.” To fix this, I had to manually edit all of the alternative responses to just “United States,” which will help make that specific country a single variable when making visualizations later on. Then, I had to classify whether a player was considered casual or competitive level. The player was considered competitive if they met any of these requirements:

- Has a rank in Lounge
- Has participated in Atlas League
- Mogi (match) queuing behavior
- High hours logged (100+ hours)
- Very high play frequency (daily or more)

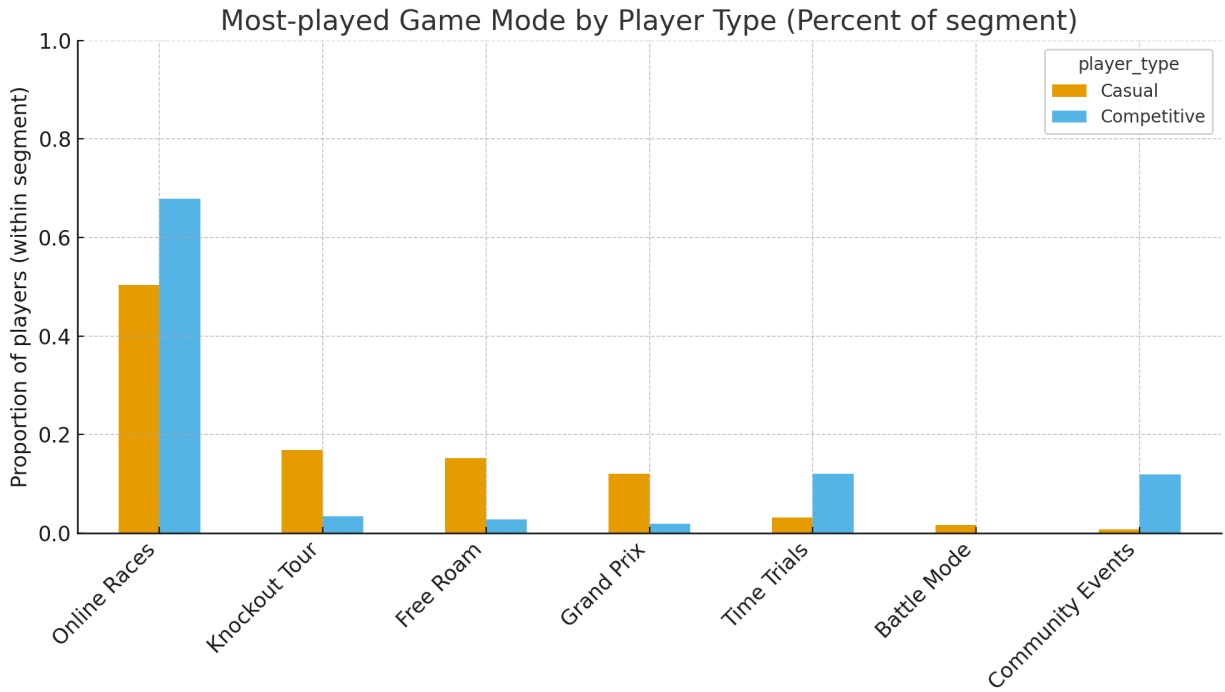
Everyone else who didn’t meet any of the above requirements was considered a casual player. Finally, I performed some analytical techniques such as cross-tabulation, grouped bar charts, chi-square tests of independence, and word-frequency analysis for open text questions, and also Python in order to make some visualizations.



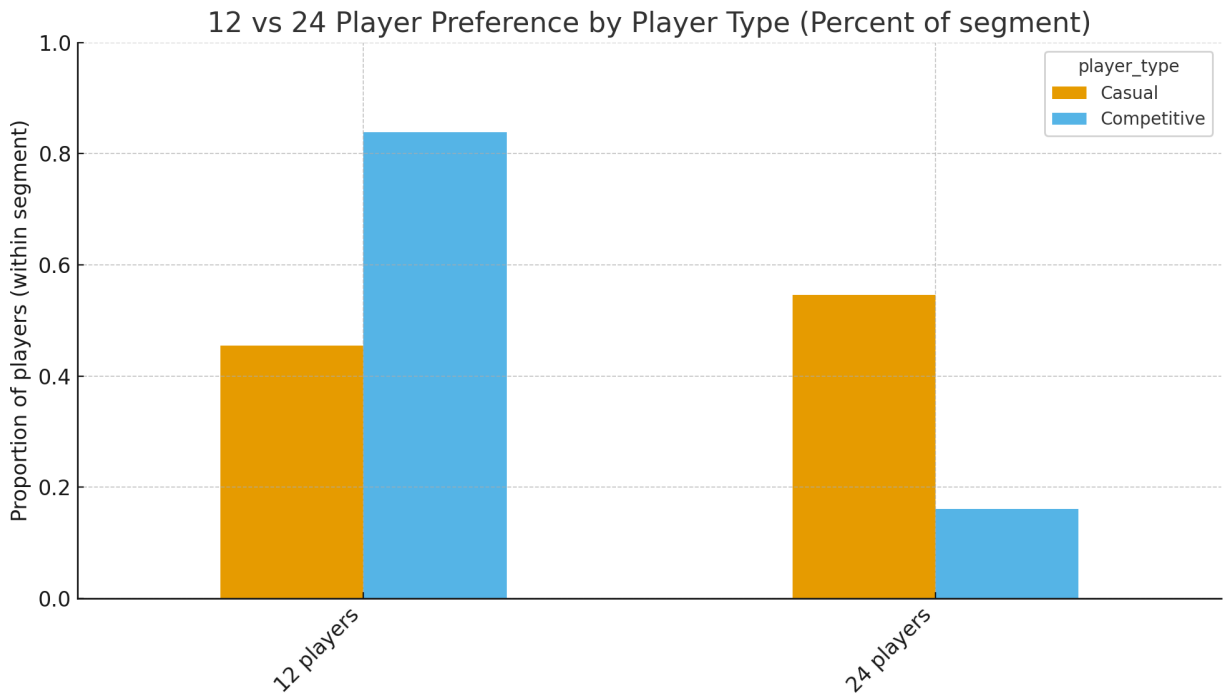
Mario Kart World Survey (Responses)							
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Form_Responses	1) What is your age?	2) What is your gender?	3) What country do you primarily play from?	4) How long have you been playing Mario Kar	5) Which Mario Kart games have you played?	6) At this point, how many hours have you log	7) How would yo
1	Timestamp						
2	10/16/2025 18:30:24	25-34	Non-binary	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart DS, Mario Kart Wii	755 Competitive
3	10/16/2025 23:51:59	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Deluxe, Mario Kart	240 Competitive
4	10/17/2025 4:22:40	25-34	Male	Germany	11+ years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart 64, Mario Ka	530 Competitive
5	10/21/2025 0:37:39	18-24	Male	Austria	4-6 years	Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 7, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Delu	~100 Competitive
6	10/21/2025 8:12:58	18-24	Female	Spain	11+ years	Mario Kart 64, Mario Kart Double Dash, Mario Kar	400+ Competitive
7	10/30/2025 7:21:15	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Double Dash, Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kar	70 Competitive
8	10/30/2025 8:05:31	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Deluxe, Mario Kart	220 Both
9	10/30/2025 9:01:33	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Double Dash, Mario Kart DS, Mario Kar	265 Competitive
10	10/30/2025 9:24:21	18-24	Male	United States of America	11+ years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart Double Dash	140 Both
11	10/30/2025 11:58:04	25-34	Female	Canada	11+ years	Mario Kart Double Dash, Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kar	Around 170? Both
12	11/7/2025 15:19:26	18-24	Male	United States	4-6 years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart 64, Mario Ka	5 Competitive
13	11/7/2025 16:26:42	18-24	Non-binary	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Super Circuit, Mario Kart DS, Mario Kar	~270 Competitive
14	11/7/2025 15:29:11	18-24	Male	United States of America	11+ years	Mario Kart DS, Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 7, Mario	265 Competitive
15	11/7/2025 15:31:14	18-24	Non-binary	United States	7-10 years	Mario Kart 7, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Deluxe, Mario Kart v	140-145 Competitive
16	11/7/2025 15:41:17	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Double Dash, Mario Kart DS, Mario Kar	345 Competitive
17	11/7/2025 15:44:02	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart 64, Mario Ka	Over 200 Competitive
18	11/7/2025 15:53:30	18-24	Male	United States of America	11+ years	Mario Kart 7, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Deluxe, Mario Kart 1	900 hours Casual
19	11/7/2025 15:58:45	15-17	Male	United States	11+ years	Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 7, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Delu	350 Competitive
20	11/7/2025 16:10:32	18-24	Female	Usa	1-3 years	Mario Kart DS, Mario Kart Wii, Mario Kart 8 / 8 Del	300 Both
21	11/7/2025 16:17:12	18-24	Male	United States	11+ years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart 64, Mario Ka	475 Both
22	11/7/2025 16:22:16	18-24	Male	Usa	4-6 years	Super Mario Kart (SNES), Mario Kart Wii, Mario K2	80 Both

Main Findings / Deliverables

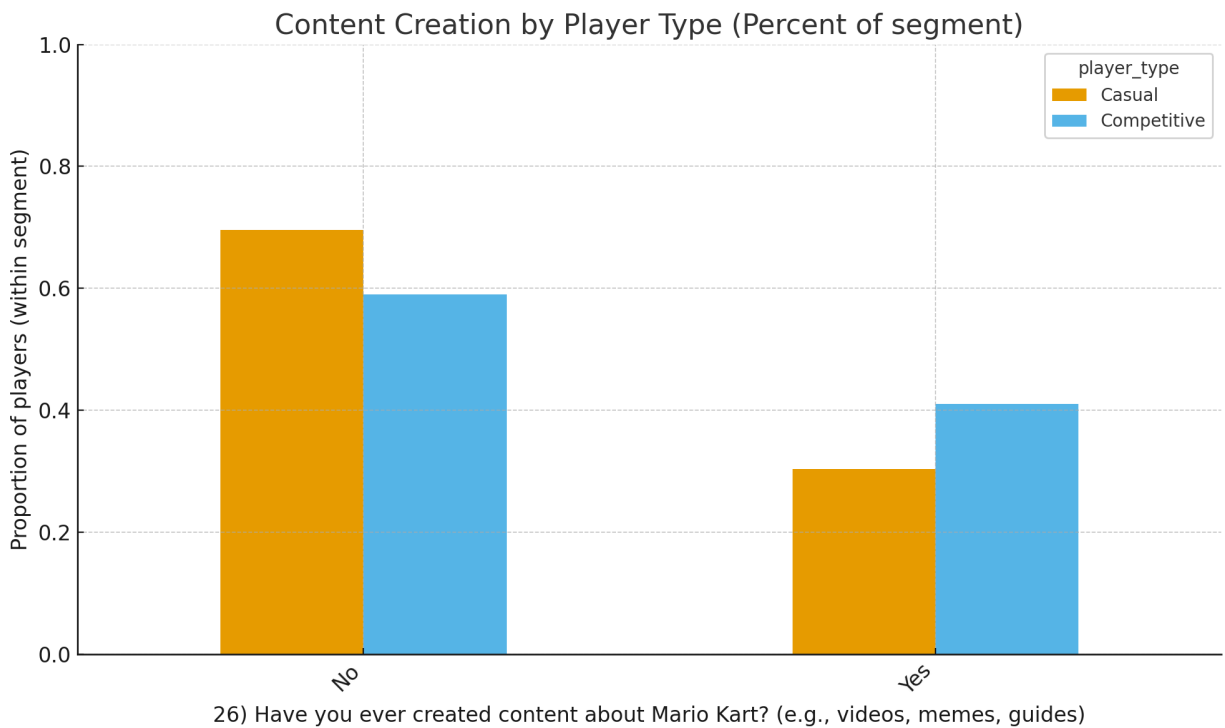
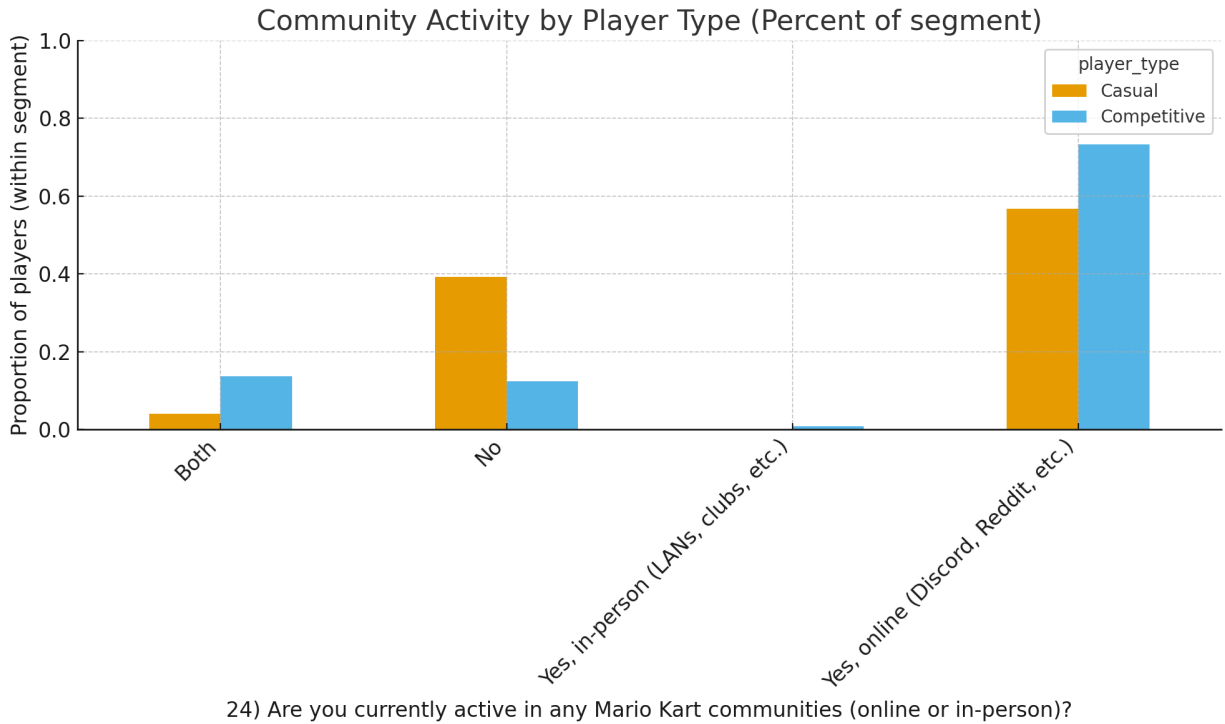
According to the dataset, there is a proportion of casual players versus competitive players. Note that the data is more skewed towards the competitive respondents which makes up about 78% of all respondents. There were some interesting findings with references to the charts that were generated. First, competitive players were significantly more active in terms of hours played and frequency. The chi-square was: $\chi^2(4) = 137.52$, $p < .001$. Competitive players prefer playing Lounge or 6v6 wars while casual players prefer playing in worldwides or private friend lobbies. The competitive players were far more active in online communities while the chi-square significance was at $p < .001$. Competitive players were also more likely to create or share content ($p \approx .039$). Additionally, competitive players strongly prefer 12-player mode while casual players prefer 24-player mode while the chi-square significance was at $p < .001$. There were also some other insights from the open-ended responses as well. One emergent theme was that most players enjoyed the new mechanics in the game such as charge jumping, air tricking, rail riding, and wall riding which makes the driving in this game pretty satisfying. Most players want Nintendo to improve the game by fixing worldwides. Many players dislike worldwides because players are forced to vote for intermission tracks instead of regular 3-lap tracks. Even if players vote for a random track, there is still a chance that the randomizer will just pick another intermission track. To combat this issue, a Mario Kart World Discord server was created where players in the server can create private lobbies and only play normal 3-lap tracks. There is also another Discord server called Mario Kart World Lounge for the competitive players where players try to score the most amount of points in a set of 12 races. Intermission tracks are banned in 12-player matches but can be picked in 24-player matches. Lastly, most players desire DLC (downloadable content) features to release in the future such as more characters, more tracks, 200cc mode, etc.



16) What game mode do you play most often?



19) Do you prefer 12 player or 24 player events?



Recommendations

Some suggestions for the game developers would be improving the matchmaking in worldwides, expanding ranked features and tooling, and adding some more modes suited to casual players,

such as family-friendly, shorter races, co-op modes, mission mode, and fixing worldwides in general, according to the survey. Some suggestions for the community managers would be supporting creators with easy-to-share highlights, encouraging casual players to join community spaces, and growing the competitive scene through events and tournaments with a ladder or power ranking visibility. Some suggestions for the content creators and coaches would be providing tutorials for casual players transitioning into competitive play, breaking down strategies to reduce the learning curve, and highlighting some fun modes to help keep the casual players engaged for as long as possible. Some suggestions for future research would be having larger sample sizes for better data, platform-level analytics rather than self-report, and longitudinal tracking of player progression over time. There was also a language barrier in the survey since English was primarily the main language. Because of this, there were only a few Japanese responses, and most of the Japanese players were excluded from filling out the survey. This could skew the data differently since most Japanese players prefer playing 24-player mode, whether it would be in casual or competitive play. In the future, I could maybe try to add a translation system in the survey or add a Japanese translation right under the questions so that I can get even more data from as many players in the community as possible.



Credit: @shamchez

Conclusion

To summarize the whole project, the main purpose of the research was to investigate the behavioral differences between casual and competitive players. Some of the key findings were that competitive players differ significantly in total amount of hours played, engagement, mode preference, social involvement, and content creation. Understanding these differences can help game developers from Nintendo tailor updates and balance content for both groups. Note that there were some limitations on the research, such as self-report, sample bias, and the Mario Kart World-specific community. At the end of the day, Mario Kart World is an amazing racing game

where players from all over the world can race each other on the race track... or intermission track!



Credit: @shamchez

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